



CULT OF BEAUTY

After 250 years, Japanese isolation from the West during the Shogun era ended, and the impact on Western fashion, art, and culture was swift. Inspired by the display of Japanese art at the International exhibition of 1862, members of the Aesthetic movement (1862–1900) with its “cult of beauty” embraced all things Japanese. E. Desoye opened a shop of Japanese curios in Paris and in 1875 Arthur Lazenby Liberty sold Japanese goods at his store, Liberty and Co. in Regent Street, London, alongside a comprehensive range of fabrics and artefacts from the Far East.

Japanese prints based on conventionalized forms of the natural world, such as flowers, birds, dragonflies, and butterflies, along with free-flowing garments, appealed to the bohemian style-makers of London, in particular Aesthetes such as Oscar Wilde and his wife Constance. Fashions such as classic Greek gowns or “Athenes”, Japanese kimonos, Indian pyjamas, and embroidered coats from China and Japan created an immediate contrast with the established, traditional Victorian dress of corsets, crinolines, and bustles, and a restricted and structured silhouette. At the Divan Japonais nightclub in Paris, fans and silks festooned the walls, and customers were attended to by waitresses dressed in kimonos. In 1876 Claude Monet painted his wife wearing a kimono in a painting entitled “La Japonaise”.

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One should either be a work of art,
or wear one.

OSCAR WILDE, 1894

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◀ JAPANESE BEAUTIES

Facsimile of a chromoxylograph by Wilhelm Greve after Katsukawa Shunsho, 1776.